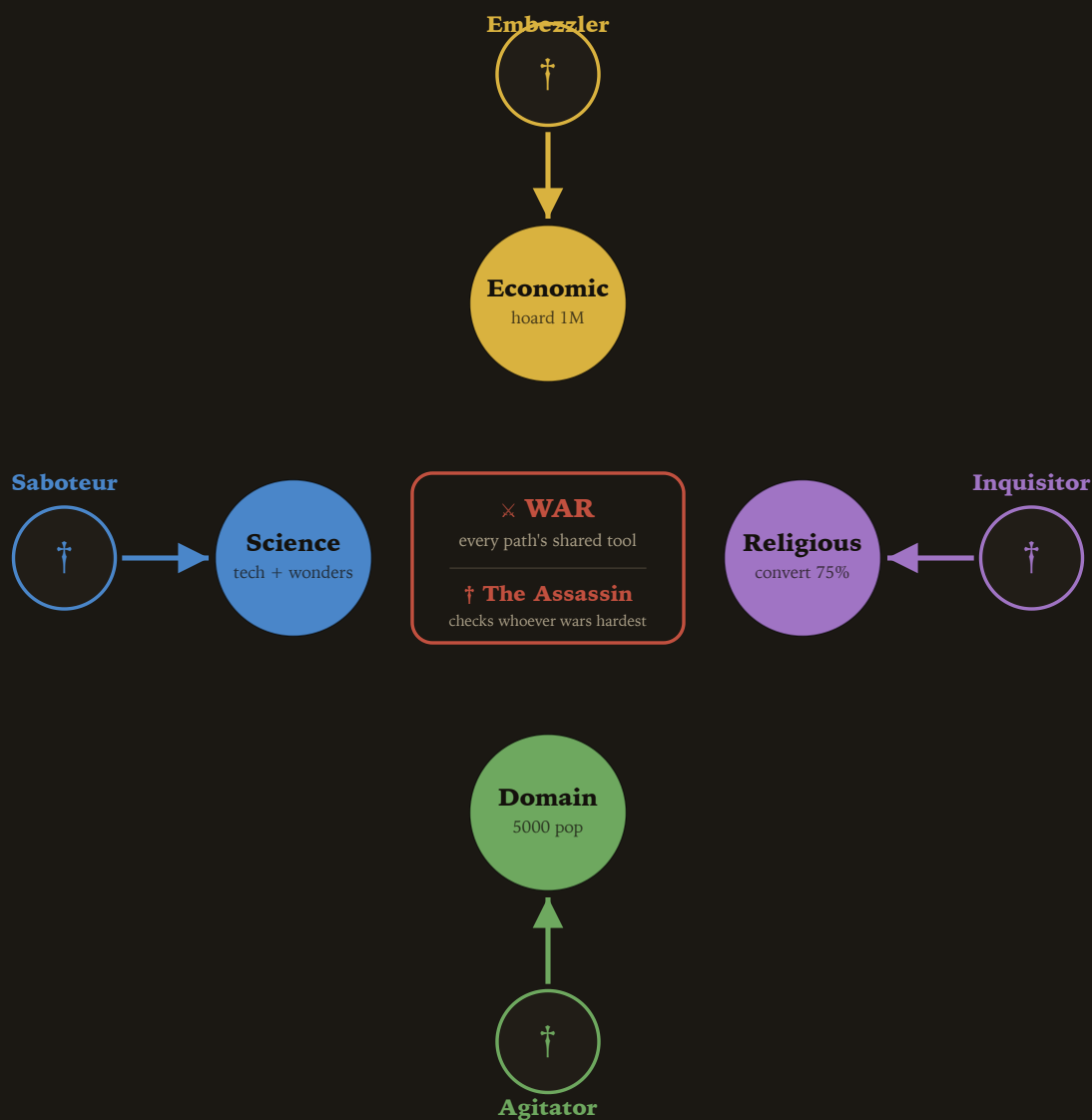


The Spy Counter-Web

Two tiers of espionage. **Four daggers for four crowns** — each victory path has exactly one spy built to threaten it. Plus **one dagger for the shared sword**: since war is now a tool every path uses, the **Assassin** sits at the center as the check on whoever leans hardest on force.



TIER 1 · PATH-COUNTERS — ONE DAGGER PER CROWN

The Embezzler

counters → **Economic** (the 1M hoard)

✂ OFFENSE
Skims gold & resources from the target's treasury into yours.

WHY IT'S THE COUNTER

The Inquisitor

counters → **Religious** (conversion %)

✂ OFFENSE
Discredits a rival faith and re-converts a slice of their flock, dropping their %.

WHY IT'S THE COUNTER

Drains the announced hoard — the reason the 30-min gold timer is contestable, not a passive win.

The only thing that can push a conversion score *backward* — without it, Religion is the safest primary.

The Saboteur

counters → **Science** (wonders / tech)

✂ OFFENSE

Wrecks a wonder's construction progress or steals a researched tech.

🛡 WHY IT'S THE COUNTER

Wonders are science-exclusive now, so they're a guaranteed target — this is what gives that path its counterplay.

The Agitator

counters → **Domain** (population)

✂ OFFENSE

Incites emigration — peasants pack up and drift toward your land instead.

🛡 WHY IT'S THE COUNTER

One dedicated pop-drain hits the census-racer directly, and doubles as fuel for your own Domain.

TIER 2 · THE TOOL-COUNTER — ONE DAGGER FOR THE SHARED SWORD

The Assassin

War tool

counters → **military aggression itself** (used by every path)

✂ OFFENSE

Kills the commander leading a raid, invasion, or garrison — briefly leaderless-ing that army and stalling the attack.

🛡 WHY IT STANDS APART

War is no longer a victory path — it's the tool that *pillages gold, annexes territory, seizes land to convert, and loots for wonders*. The Assassin is the check on whoever leans hardest on that tool, whatever crown they're chasing.

What changed when Military stopped being a path

Before: five crowns, and the Assassin was the counter to a Military *victory*. **After:** four crowns each with a dedicated path-counter, and the Assassin is promoted to the center as the counter to the *war tool* — so it stays relevant against all four paths (each of which now uses force to feed its own engine) instead of guarding a crown that no longer exists.

The law holds at both tiers: a spy is never generic harassment — it is the specific answer either to one way of winning, or to the one tool everyone shares.